A GRIMOIRE OF THE OLD RELIGIONS · VOL. II

The Celtic Grimoire

The old ways of Ireland, Wales, and Gaul

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The book is planned at 150 pages, and page counts are the planned lengths. Chapters with a plan page list what each page will cover, and the pages written so far follow it.

Welcome

Working with the Old Ways

Working with the Old Ways

Rest your tired bones and troubled mind. This book shares the old Celtic ways, which were about keeping good company with the living, the dead, the land, and the Otherworld next door. If parts of it do not fit your life or beliefs, leave them behind and keep what helps. I have tried to present these old ways as accurately as the sources allow, and I say where each claim comes from. Use the prompt at the end of each page, and the lined pages, to write, reflect, and build your own practice. Write your answers on a lined page or in a notebook of your own, and date them.

"Celtic" is a modern word for peoples who spoke related languages: Gaulish, Irish, Welsh, and their kin. They never shared one religion or one government, so this book keeps Ireland, Wales, and Gaul apart, and says which one it means on every page.

This book mentions plants from medieval medical books and folk custom, but it does not replace a doctor. Never eat, drink, or apply any plant from these pages based on this book alone.

Where this comes from: Every lore page ends with a short note that says where its ideas come from: a poem, a tale, a stone, a custom, or this book. If a source is late, or scholars disagree, the note says so. Anything described as modern or rebuilt was written for your home and is not an old practice.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

What season is it today, outside your actual window? Name three signs.

How to say the names

Irish and Welsh names look hard, but a few rules cover most of them. In Irish, *bh* and *mh* sound like v or w, *dh* and *gh* are soft or silent, and *ch* is like the end of "loch." An accent mark lengthens a vowel. In Welsh, *dd* is the "th" in this, *f* is v, *w* is often "oo," and *ll* is a breathy l. Every name below has more than one accepted way to say it.

Samhain: SOW-in or SAH-win
Imbolc: IM-ulk
Beltaine: BYEL-tin-eh
Lughnasadh: LOO-na-sa
Dagda: DAG-da
Lugh: LOO
Brigid: BREE-id
Morrígan: MOR-ree-gan
Tuatha Dé Danann: TOO-a-ha day DAN-an
Cú Chulainn: koo KHUL-in
Fionn: FYUN
Oisín: UH-sheen
Rhiannon: hree-AN-on
Annwn: AN-oon
Taliesin: tal-YES-in
Cerridwen: keh-RID-wen
ogham: OH-um

These are English-friendly approximations. Say them aloud once, and they will stay with you.

Where this comes from: Standard Irish and Welsh pronunciation guides, simplified for English readers.

The Sources

what we know and how

Planned pages

Who wrote about the Celts — the sources at a glance
[written]

Roman and Greek writers — Caesar, Strabo, Diodorus, Pliny, Tacitus, and why each is hostile or second-hand
the writers themselves

Irish manuscripts — the Book of Leinster, Lebor na hUidre, the tale lists
medieval manuscripts

Welsh manuscripts — the White Book of Rhydderch, Red Book of Hergest, Book of Taliesin
medieval manuscripts

What the ground gives us — Coligny calendar, Gundestrup cauldron, Llyn Cerrig Bach, La Tène, ogham stones
archaeology

Folk collections, and what they are — Carmina Gadelica (1900) and the Physicians of Myddfai: late, and labeled so
Carmichael; Myddfai

This chapter is planned at 7 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Who wrote about the Celts

No Celtic priest left a book. What we know comes from Roman and Greek writers, from medieval monks, and from the ground. Here is who is who.

Caesar, 50s BCE: *The Gallic War*, book 6: druids, Gaulish society, and gods named by Roman names.
Diodorus and Strabo, around the turn of the era: Gaulish feasts, bards, and severed heads, passed down from an earlier Greek traveler, Posidonius.
Pliny the Elder, 77 CE: Mistletoe, oak, and the herbs the druids gathered.
Tacitus, about 116 CE: The Roman attack on the druids' island of Mona in 60 CE.
Irish manuscripts, 1100s: The Book of Leinster and others keep older tales, written down by Christian monks.
Welsh manuscripts, 1300s: The Mabinogi and the poems of Taliesin, in the White Book of Rhydderch and the Red Book of Hergest.
The ground: The Coligny calendar from Gaul, the Gundestrup cauldron, the Llyn Cerrig Bach hoard on Anglesey, and 400 ogham stones.

Ask who wrote each source and why. The Romans wrote about enemies, and the monks wrote after the old religion had faded.

Where this comes from: The authors and works named here. Dates are approximate.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which source would you most like to read first? Name it and why.*

Who Were the Celts

peoples, places, and a hard truth

Planned pages

Who were the Celts — a language family, not a nation
[written]

Keep the places apart — Gaul, Ireland, Wales, Scotland and Man
[written]

Peoples at a glance — Gauls, Britons, Gaels, Galatians (list)
Greek and Roman writers

Society at a glance — kings, druids, filid, warriors, farmers, Brehon law (list)
Caesar; Irish law texts

The door and the guest — hospitality as law: the hostel, the host's duty
Togail Bruidne Da Derga; Irish law

Fosterage and kin — raising other people's children; the bond that followed
Irish and Welsh law and tales

This chapter is planned at 7 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Who were the Celts

The Celts are peoples who spoke Celtic languages, one branch of the Indo-European family. By about 400 BCE, Celtic speakers lived from Spain to Turkey. The best known are the Gauls in what is now France, the Britons in Britain, and the Gaels in Ireland, later Scotland and the Isle of Man.

They never formed one nation, and "Celtic" was not their own name for themselves. Greek writers called the Gauls *Keltoi*. The word is now a label for a language family. The evidence differs by place: the Gauls are known from Roman writers and archaeology, while Ireland and Wales are known from medieval manuscripts, written by Christians after the old religions had faded.

That is why this book keeps its places apart. When a page says "Irish," it means Irish. When it says "Gaulish," it means Gaul.

Where this comes from: Celtic languages are known from inscriptions and manuscripts. The names Keltoi and Galatai are from Greek writers.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find Gaul, Britain, and Ireland on a map. Write one thing each place is known for in the sources.*

Keep the places apart

Gaul: Known from Roman writers and archaeology. The gods have Roman names in the writers, and Gaulish names on altars: Cernunnos, Epona, Taranis.
Ireland: Known from tales written by Christian monks from about 1100, which keep older material: the Tuatha Dé Danann, the Ulster heroes, the four fires, and the Brehon laws.
Wales: Known from the Mabinogi and the poems of Taliesin, copied in the 1300s: Rhiannon, Bran, Cerridwen, and the deep land of Annwn.
Scotland and Man: Known mostly from folk prayers and charms collected in the 1800s, the Carmina Gadelica, which are late.

Do not blend them. A god in an Irish tale is not the same as a god on a Gaulish altar, even when the names look alike.

Where this comes from: The sources named on the previous page. The Carmina Gadelica was collected by Alexander Carmichael and published in 1900.

The Otherworld and the Land

land, sea, sky, and the place beside them

Planned pages

Land, sea, and sky — the three divisions of the Irish world
Irish texts

The Otherworld at a glance — every named Otherworld (list)
[written]

The sídhe — where the Tuatha Dé went underground
Irish tales

Journeys across — Bran, Oisín, and Pwyll
Immram Brain; Oisín; the Mabinogi

Tara and Uisneach — the centres of Ireland
Irish tales; archaeology

Doors and edges — shores, mounds, and Samhain night as crossing times
Irish tales

This chapter is planned at 7 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

The Otherworld at a glance

The Celts did not describe one afterlife. Each place told it differently. Here are the main names.

Tír na nÓg (Ireland): the land of the young, from the later tale of Oisín.
Mag Mell (Ireland): the plain of delight, a happy land across the sea.
Emain Ablach (Ireland): the isle of apples, home of Manannán.
Tech Duinn (Ireland): the house of Donn, where the dead gather.
The sídhe (Ireland): the hills and mounds where the Tuatha Dé went.
Annwn (Wales): the deep, ruled by Arawn, whom Pwyll visits in the Mabinogi.
Caer Sidi (Wales): the turning fortress, in the poems of Taliesin.
Gaul: no land is named, but Caesar says the druids taught that the soul passes from one body to another.

Where this comes from: The Irish tales, the Mabinogi, the Book of Taliesin, and Caesar's *Gallic War*. Tír na nÓg is from a late tale.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which Otherworld would you most like to read about? Name it and why.*

Gods and Powers

Ireland, Wales, and Gaul, kept apart

Planned pages (1 of 2)

How the three groups differ — the divine peoples of each place
[summary]

The Tuatha Dé Danann at a glance — list
[written]

The Dagda — club and cauldron
Cath Maige Tuired

Lugh — the many-skilled
Cath Maige Tuired

Brigit: goddess and saint — the goddess and the saint, kept apart
[written]

The Morrígan and her kin — Badb, Macha, Nemain
Irish tales

Manannán mac Lir — the sea
Irish tales

The craft gods — Dian Cécht, Goibniu, Credne, Luchta
Cath Maige Tuired

The Welsh gods at a glance — list
the Mabinogi; Welsh poems

Rhiannon — horse, birds, and a hard bargain
the Mabinogi

Bran the Blessed — the head that spoke
the Mabinogi

Cerridwen — the cauldron
the tale of Taliesin

This chapter is planned at 19 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Planned pages (2 of 2)

Arawn — the king of Annwn
the Mabinogi

The Gaulish gods at a glance — list
altars and Roman writers

Cernunnos — the antlered one
Pillar of the Boatmen; Gundestrup

Epona — the horse goddess
altars across the Roman world

Sulis and the water goddesses — Bath, the Seine, the Boyne
altars; Irish tales

The Mothers — triple goddesses on Gaulish-Roman reliefs
reliefs

Battle goddesses — Morrígan, Badb, Macha, taken together
Irish tales

This chapter is planned at 19 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

The Tuatha Dé Danann at a glance

The Irish tales name a divine people, the Tuatha Dé Danann, "the people of the goddess Danu." They fight the Fomorians and later go into the hills. Here are the best known.

The Dagda: the great father, with a club and a bottomless cauldron.
Lugh: the many-skilled, who kills the giant Balor.
Nuada: the king with the silver arm.
Brigit: poetry, healing, and smithcraft.
Dian Cécht: the healer.
Goibniu: the smith.
Ogma: the warrior-poet, said to have invented ogham.
The Morrígan: battle and sovereignty, with Badb and Macha.
Manannán mac Lir: the sea, with a cloak of mist.
Aengus Óg: love and youth, at Brú na Bóinne.
Boann: the river Boyne.

Where this comes from: Cath Maige Tuired (The Second Battle of Mag Tuired) and the other Irish tales, written down about 1100 and later. Danu is named in few sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these would you most like to meet? Name them and why.*

Brigit: goddess and saint

Brigit is a goddess of poetry, healing, and smithcraft. Cormac's Glossary, an Irish word-book from about 900, calls her "the woman of wisdom" and "the goddess whom poets adored." It says she had two sisters, also named Brigit: one a healer and one a smith.

Saint Brigid of Kildare has the same name. Tradition places her in the 5th or 6th century, with a feast on 1 February, the day of Imbolc. The saint cares for cattle, milk, and healing, and around 1185 Gerald of Wales described a fire kept burning at Kildare. Scholars still argue about how much of the saint belongs to the goddess.

This book tells the two apart. The goddess is in Cormac's Glossary and the Irish tales. The saint is in the lives written by monks.

Where this comes from: Cormac's Glossary (about 900) and the lives of Saint Brigid. The link between the two is debated.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of Brigit's three crafts is nearest to yours? Name one, and why.*

Tales

stories from the old books

Planned pages

The Second Battle of Mag Tuired — Lugh, Balor, the end of the Fomorians
Irish tales

Cú Chulainn takes arms — the boy who guarded Ulster
the Táin

Cú Chulainn at the ford — the single combat with Ferdiad
the Táin

The salmon of knowledge — Fionn's thumb
[written]

The Children of Lir — four swans, nine hundred years
Irish tales

Oisín in Tír na nÓg — three hundred years in a night
Irish tales

Pwyll and Arawn — a year in another man's place
the Mabinogi

Branwen and the head of Bran — war, and the head that spoke
the Mabinogi

Blodeuwedd — the woman made of flowers
the Mabinogi

Taliesin — the boy who stirred the cauldron
the tale of Taliesin

Welsh Triads — three of this, three of that (list)
the Triads of the Island of Britain

This chapter is planned at 12 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

The salmon of knowledge

A young man named Fionn goes to study with the poet Finnegas, who has spent seven years beside the Boyne waiting for one fish. The salmon had eaten the nuts of the nine hazels that grow around the well of wisdom, and whoever eats it will know everything.

Finnegas catches the salmon and tells Fionn to cook it, but not to eat any. As Fionn turns the fish, its skin blisters his thumb, and he sticks the thumb in his mouth. From that day, whenever Fionn puts his thumb in his mouth, he knows what is hidden.

The tale links wisdom with water, hazel, and patience, and it says wisdom may come by accident. It is told in the Irish tales of Fionn's boyhood.

Where this comes from: The medieval Irish tale of Fionn's boyhood deeds, Macgnímartha Find.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Where did you learn something by accident? Write it in one sentence.*

Druids, Poets, and Seers

the learned class

Planned pages

Who were the druids — what Caesar and Pliny say, and don't
Caesar; Pliny

The attack on Mona — the Roman assault of 60 CE
Tacitus

The filid and the bards — the Irish poets, their training and rank
Irish law texts

Imbas forosnai — the poet's vision
[written]

Women seers — Fedelm in the Táin and others
the Táin

Taliesin and Myrddin — poet and wild prophet in Wales
Welsh poems

Sitting out and sleeping on it — the tarbfeis and the wild madman's year
Togail Bruidne Da Derga; Buile Suibhne

This chapter is planned at 8 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Imbas forosnai: the poet's vision

Imbas forosnai means roughly "knowledge that illuminates." Cormac's Glossary, written by a Christian about 900, describes it as a rite of the Irish poets, the filid. The poet chews a piece of raw flesh, puts it on a flat stone behind the door, chants over it, and calls on gods whose names the glossator does not give. Then he sleeps with his palms on his cheeks, while others watch over him, until the answer is revealed.

A related rite, the *tarbfeis*, is described in another tale. A man eats his fill of a bull killed for a feast and drinks its broth while a spell is chanted over him. Then he sleeps, and the man he sees in his dream is the next king.

Notice what we have: a hostile description by a monk, not a manual. We do not know how the poets said it, or what the words were. This book gives no instructions, because the sources give none.

Where this comes from: Cormac's Glossary (Sanas Chormaic) and the Irish tale Togail Bruidne Da Derga. Both were written by Christians.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What would you want a vision to tell you? Write the question, and leave it unanswered.*

Truth and Oath

the Celtic form of luck

Planned pages

What a geis is — taboos of the heroes (list)
[written]

The ruler's truth — fír flathemon: a true king brings a good year
Irish law and tales

Oaths by the elements — swearing by sky, sea, and earth
Irish tales; Caesar

Your vow — a lined page, built on oath-taking
lined page

This chapter is planned at 5 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

What a geis is

A *geis* is a taboo laid on a person in Irish tales. Keep it, and you are safe. Break it, and your doom follows. The best known belong to heroes.

Cú Chulainn: forbidden to eat dog, and forbidden to refuse hospitality. A hag offers him dog meat and he eats, and he dies.
Conaire Mór: a king bound by many taboos, who breaks them one by one and is killed in a hostel.
Diarmuid: forbidden to hunt a boar, and killed by one.

Notice the pattern: a geis binds the best of the people, and fate finds the gap between two of them.

Where this comes from: Aided Con Culainn (Cú Chulainn's Death), Togail Bruidne Da Derga, and the tale of Diarmuid and Gráinne.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these taboos would be hardest to keep? Name it, and say why.*

The Other People

the aos sí, in sources and in folklore

Planned pages

Who the aos sí are — medieval tales versus 19th-century folklore, kept apart
Irish tales; folklore

Fairy hills and thorns — places people leave alone
folklore, labeled late

Changelings and folk rules — what folklore says, labeled as such
folklore

Leaving things alone — a practice built on documented custom
folklore

This chapter is planned at 5 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

The Four Fires

Samhain, Imbolc, Beltaine, Lughnasadh

Planned pages

An honest wheel — four fires, not eight spokes
[written]

How each fire works here — the pattern for the chapter
[summary]

The Coligny sidebar — the calendar from Gaul
the Coligny bronze

Samhain, two pages — the dead, the Mag Tuired battle, a feast
Irish tales

Imbolc, two pages — Brigit, ewes' milk, a first stir of spring
Cormac's Glossary; later custom

Beltaine, two pages — the two fires, the herd
[written] and Cormac's Glossary

Lughnasadh, two pages — Tailtiu's fair, games, and marriages
Irish tales

The champion's portion — feasting rank and the gift of meat
Fled Bricrenn

Moon tracker — two months of looking up
calendar sticks and the Coligny calendar

Gift log — what you gave and to whom
built on the feast pages

This chapter is planned at 15 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

An honest wheel

The Irish year had four great feasts: Samhain on 1 November, Imbolc on 1 February, Beltaine on 1 May, and Lughnasadh on 1 August. They are named in Irish texts from about 900 to 1200, and in Cormac's Glossary. The Coligny calendar from Gaul, of the 2nd century CE, shows month names and a cycle of years. One month, Samonios, may be related to Samhain.

The eight-spoke Wheel of the Year, with solstices and equinoxes, was put together in the 20th century. It is a modern tool, not an old Celtic one. There is no evidence that the solstices and equinoxes were Celtic feasts, even though older monuments like Newgrange line up with the sun.

This book follows the four fires. It marks thin evidence as thin.

Where this comes from: The four feasts are named in Irish texts and Cormac's Glossary. The Coligny calendar is a bronze tablet from France. The eight-spoke wheel is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find which of the four fires comes next, and mark its date in ink.*

Beltaine: the two fires

Beltaine, on 1 May, opens the summer half of the year. Cormac's Glossary says the name has to do with two fires, or a "lucky fire." It says the druids lit two fires with incantations and drove the cattle between them each year, as protection against disease.

Scholars still argue over the exact meaning of the glossary entry. Later Irish and Scottish folk custom, recorded in the 1700s and 1800s, kept bonfires and cattle-driving at the start of May, and the Carmina Gadelica records prayers for the cattle and the dairy.

The old purpose is plain: protect the herd as it goes out to summer pasture. [Practice to be written from the sources.]

Where this comes from: Cormac's Glossary (about 900). The later customs are from folk records.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What would you protect as you go into summer? Name it.*

Plants and Trees

what the sources say

Planned pages

Healing plants in the sources — Pliny, Airmed, Myddfai
[written]

Mistletoe and oak — Pliny's rite, with its doubts
Pliny

Selago, samolus, and vervain — Pliny's herbs and the rules for gathering
Pliny

Airmed's 365 herbs — the myth
Cath Maige Tuired

The Physicians of Myddfai — remedies from a Welsh family of healers
Myddfai manuscripts

Hazel and the well of wisdom — nine hazels, the salmon
Irish tales

The Battle of the Trees — alder, rowan, and the poem
the Book of Taliesin

Oak, yew, and apple — the sacred trees of the tales
Irish and Welsh tales

Safety page — read first
plain fact

This chapter is planned at 10 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Healing plants in the sources

No Celtic herbal survives from the Iron Age. What we have is scattered. Pliny the Elder says Gaulish druids cut mistletoe from an oak on the sixth day of the moon, with a golden sickle, and caught it in a white cloth. He also names selago, a plant gathered without iron, and samolus, a marsh plant gathered by a fasting person with the left hand.

Irish myth says that after the healer Dian Cécht kills his son Miach, 365 herbs grow from the grave, one for each joint and sinew of the body, and Miach's sister Airmed gathers them. In Wales, the Physicians of Myddfai were a family of healers whose remedies were written down from about the 1300s.

Pliny was a Roman writing about another people, and the Irish tale is a myth. This book records them as history. It does not recommend any plant. If you are unwell, see a clinician.

Where this comes from: Pliny's *Natural History* (77 CE), Cath Maige Tuired, and the Red Book of Hergest.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these plants have you seen growing near you? Note where. Do not pick it.*

Sacred Places

water, hills, and groves

Planned pages

Wells and springs — Sulis at Bath, Coventina, the well of Segais
altars and tablets; Irish tales

Rivers and their goddesses — the Boyne, the Seine
Irish tales; altars

Fords — where combats and laws were held
the Táin

Hills and royal sites — Tara, Uisneach, Emain Macha
tales; archaeology

Caves and doors — Oweynagat, the cave of Cruachan
Irish tales

Groves — the nemeton: a word in place names
Roman writers; place names

Gifts in water — La Tène, Llyn Cerrig Bach, Flag Fen
archaeology

This chapter is planned at 8 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Ogham

the letters of the old Irish

Planned pages

What ogham is
[written]

The first family: Beithe
[written]

The second family: hÚath
ogham treatises and stones

The third family: Muin
ogham treatises and stones

The fourth family: Ailm
ogham treatises and stones

The extra letters — the forfeda, added later
ogham treatises

Reading a stone — the "of X, son of Y" formula, with examples
the stones

Ogham in the tales — Cú Chulainn cuts ogham on a withy
the Táin

Writing your name — a worked example and a chart
the chart

Carving ogham — wood, a central line, and the strokes
practical

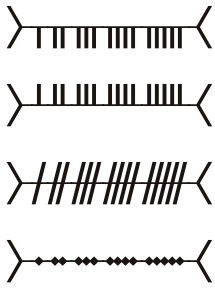
The tree alphabet: old and modern — what is medieval, and what Robert Graves invented in 1948
the treatises; Graves

This chapter is planned at 12 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

What ogham is

Ogham (OH-um) is an alphabet of straight strokes cut along the edge of a standing stone. About 400 stones survive, most in southern Ireland and Wales, from about the 4th to the 6th century CE. The tallest, the Ballycrovane stone in County Cork, stands about 4.7 meters high.

Its twenty letters fall in four groups of five, called *aicmí* (families). The strokes sit on, across, or below a central line, which is the stone's edge. Most inscriptions are names in the form "of X, son of Y." Scholars think ogham was made by Irish speakers who knew the Latin alphabet, so it grew out of contact with Rome. Medieval writers credit the god Ogma.



Above is the whole alphabet, one family to a line.

Where this comes from: The ogham stones themselves, and the medieval Irish texts that name the letters. The Latin link is the usual scholarly view.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Copy the twenty letters once, slowly.*

The first family: Beithe

The first family is named for its first letter, Beithe (birch). Its five letters are cut as strokes to the right of the line.

	**Beithe**	*b*	birch
	**Luis**	*l*	flame or herb; later glossed as rowan
	**Fern**	*f* or *v*	alder
	**Sail**	*s*	willow
	**Nin**	*n*	uncertain; later glossed as ash

Only about five of the twenty letter names are certainly trees. The others have uncertain meanings, and the tree readings come from medieval glosses. The "tree calendar" sold today was invented in the 20th century.

Where this comes from: The medieval ogham treatises and the stones. The modern tree calendar is not old.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Say the five names aloud, then copy the five letters.*

Symbols

what is old and what is newer

Planned pages

Old signs and newer ones — list with a drawing
[written]

The spiral and the triskele — what the carvings show
archaeology

The torc and the cauldron — gold at the neck, a pot at the feast
graves; Gundestrup; the Irish tales

This chapter is planned at 4 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Old signs and newer ones

Spiral and triple spiral: carved at Newgrange in Ireland about 3200 BCE, long before the Celts. Later Celtic metalwork reused spirals.
Triskele: three-armed spirals on Celtic metalwork from about the 5th century BCE.
Torc: a neck ring, found in Gaulish graves and worn by gods and heroes in art.
Knotwork: from Insular Christian art, as in the Book of Kells, about 800 CE. It is not pre-Christian.
Celtic cross: Christian, from the high crosses of the 8th to 10th centuries.
Awen: three rays, said to be a bardic sign, but invented in the 1790s by Iolo Morganwg.

Only the first three are old. The rest are later, and the pages say when.

Where this comes from: Newgrange and La Tène metalwork are known from archaeology. The Book of Kells is a Christian manuscript. The awen is a modern invention.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sketch a triple spiral from a photograph of a carving. Note where it was found.*

Charms and Prayers

what words survive

Planned pages

Gaulish words in Latin books — Marcellus of Bordeaux
[written]

Lead tablets — Larzac and Chamalières
the tablets

The Deer's Cry — an Irish prayer that names the elements
a medieval text

The caim — the encircling prayer
Carmina Gadelica, labeled late

Learn a prayer — a practice built on the Deer's Cry
the Deer's Cry

This chapter is planned at 6 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Gaulish words in Latin books

Marcellus of Bordeaux, a Gaulish official, wrote a Latin book of remedies about 400 CE, *De medicamentis*. It includes spoken charms, some of them in words scholars read as Gaulish. One is for the eye.

Gaulish also survives on lead. The Larzac tablet, from about 100 CE, is the longest known Gaulish text, and it is a spell written by women. Scholars can read only part of it.

So the oldest real Celtic charms are a few phrases in a Latin book and a few lead tablets. This book gives no instructions, because we cannot read enough to give them.

Where this comes from: Marcellus's *De medicamentis* and the Larzac lead tablet. Both are partly understood.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these two would you most like to see? Name it, and why.*

The Dead and the Ancestors

mounds, feasts, and names

Planned pages

Mounds and tombs — Newgrange, passage tombs, barrows
archaeology

Feasts for the dead — Samhain and the funeral feast
Irish tales

Names and pedigrees — reciting your descent, as the Irish did
Irish genealogies

Tech Duinn — the house where the dead gather
Irish tales

This chapter is planned at 5 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.

Reference

resources, reading, and a glossary

Planned pages

Resources — books behind this book
list

Go on reading — primary texts in translation
list

Words in this book — Irish and Welsh terms, two pages
list

Lined pages — ten, placed after the practice chapters
lined

This chapter is planned at 14 pages, including its divider. Entries marked [written] appear in full later in this chapter.